



“In the past, insurers used to be reluctant to provide health insurance to senior citizens, but that is no longer the case”

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“Co-morbid health conditions may lead to higher claim outflow of an insurer and hence the premiums are generally higher in comparison to customers who are younger”

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“Options such as deductions, co-payment and portability can help senior citizens in reducing their premium rates”

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by their current insurer. Policyholders can switch their policies from group to individual policies or from individual to individual policies as well, where the benefits accrued in the previous policy will be carried on to the new policy after portability. The porting request has to be initiated 45 days before the policy's renewal date, with the policyholder required to complete the formalities requested by the new insurer. “The new insurer will reach out to the previous insurer to understand the insured's medical and claims history. Post the requisite due diligence, the policy may be accepted by the new insurer, who may also suggest revisions in the policy,” says Singhel. But the company can also deny such a request as per its underwriting norms and guidelines.

Keep in mind that porting is only allowed while renewing a policy. The new insurer has to offer the same sum insured, and with any waiting period completed with the old insurer being continued.

Modular Policy: These days, insurers are willing to customise their policies to align with your needs. Hence, if you need a waiver on pre-existing diseases or need a shorter waiting period before the coverage kicks in, then insurers can customise the policy as per your needs. Similarly, if you want to introduce a co-payment or a deductible clause in the policy to reduce your premium, you can do so. You can also buy a floater health insurance with your spouse to reduce the premium outgo.

Health Fund: If you find that your current policy does not provide a favourable risk-return equation, you may consider investing in debt funds or fixed deposits to create a substantial health fund. Moreover, it is always pertinent to establish such a health fund because many illnesses are not covered under regular policies. And if you are not prepared for such emergencies, they

can have a significant impact on your finances.

The good part is that health insurers today have understood the challenges a policyholder faces, and hence curated products that offer better coverage, control and care to senior citizens. For instance, the latest products cover charges such as teleconsultations, annual health check-ups and second-opinion consultations, apart from offering lower waiting periods for pre-existing conditions. Not only that, plans, such as one from Care Health, covers senior citizens up to the age of 98 years.

Similarly, ManipalCigna has a policy called ‘ManipalCigna Prime Senior’ that gives flexibility in terms of lower waiting periods and provides coverage for pre-existing diseases from 91 days after enrolling in the policy. “There are products in the market that are more affordable, predictable, and simple. We are seeing a gradual change in the landscape of health insurance for senior citizens, and insurers are now curating products that will ultimately benefit the customers,” says Sikdar.

Finally, it is always advisable to buy health insurance early in life. Buying a cover early on can ensure that the waiting period for any pre-existing disease is completed at a young age. One can also increase the coverage for any non-claim year by getting a no-claim bonus or NCB—a reward for not raising any claims in a particular year—from the insurer. “There is a significant difference in the premium of a young person versus a senior citizen. However, this may vary from insurer to insurer,” says Chaturvedi of Go Digit. He further explains that Go Digit has devised an age band for premiums instead of charging higher premium age-wise so that rates stay constant for everyone in the same age band. All of this means that there are a number of ways for people, especially senior citizens, to keep a tab on increasing premium rates. **BT**

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